THE FUTURE ARCHEOLOGY OF POPULAR MUSIC: MEDIA, AURA, *VANITAS*

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ABSTRACT.

This talk will examine the core questions posed by my sound installation *Popular Archeology: Cassette, c. 1967-1994* (2010) which interrogates the myth of spatiotemporal totality that characterises the online era, an era in which the entire world is purportedly available in digitised form. But has music's shift to digital disembodiment, via an ongoing series of format changes, left in its wake a trail of superceded objects, devices and media? Some of these live a shadow life as retro-fetish objects: LPs and cassettes continue to circulate where mini-disc and 8-track cassette appear consigned to history. The former have durability greater than digital media, yet the wear of time cannot be effaced from them. Unless digitised they go the way of all flesh, slipping into decrepitude, prey to the imperfections of embodied memory. Does this senescence reinstate a Benjaminian aura to these artifacts of mass (re)production, given that the decay of each object is unique and not reproducible? The installation sonically enacts such a process of techno-cultural decay by simulating accelerated temporality, creating a cloud of sonic dust, out of which emerged privileged remnants: the hooks, licks and phrases crucial to the success of popular music. Is such a process to be read as analog nostalgia for a digital age, or is there something with greater longevity at work here, such as a contemporary iteration of the *vanitas* trope? These questions form the framework for my analysis of the installation, which in turn is directed towards a deeper analysis of the relationship between music, technology and memory, within the contexts of popular music and sound-based art.

Popular Archeology: Cassette, c. 1967-1994 (2010)
35 cassette players and cassette loops, shelving, disused retail space
http://www.lettingspace.org.nz/dugal-mckinnon/



Dugal McKinnon – Biography

Dugal McKinnon is a composer of electronic, instrumental and multimedia work, a sound artist and a writer on contemporary music. His work has received performances in Australasia, Europe, North America and Asia. Current projects include new works for saxophonist Richard Haynes (AUS) and the Lunapark ensemble (NL), both developed during an artist residency at the Centre for Art and Media Technology (ZKM) in Karlsruhe (DE). He is co-director with Sophie Jerram of Now Future, an organisation founded to foster interdisciplinary research and production at the intersection of art and ecology (www.nowfuture.org.nz). Dugal holds a PhD in Composition from the University of Birmingham (UK), where he studied with Dr Jonty Harrison. His doctorate was completed while on a DAAD Stipendium at the Technische Universität Berlin. He teaches sonic art and composition at the New Zealand School of Music (Wellington, NZ) where he is the director of the Lilburn Electroacoustic Music Studios.